

DIGITALKARTAI PRESENTS

The Festive Seller Playbook 2026

Big Billion Days. Great Indian Festival. Navratri to Diwali.

The complete small-seller playbook for India's biggest shopping season - channels, pricing math, deals, ads, GST 2.0 and cash flow, verified for 2026.

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1. The five-week window that pays for the whole year

Every September and October, Indian online retail compresses a quarter's worth of demand into about five weeks. In 2025 those weeks crossed Rs 1.15 lakh crore in gross sales for e-commerce platforms, growing 20 to 25 percent over the previous year. For 2026, Redseer Strategy Consultants - the Bengaluru firm whose festive estimates the industry treats as the reference - expects the festive window to grow about 25 percent again, to roughly USD 15-16 billion, with 180 to 185 million shoppers participating. India's full-year online retail is on track to cross USD 90 billion, the fastest growth in five years.

Two marketplace events anchor the season. Flipkart's Big Billion Days 2026 was announced on 16 September 2026: early access opens on 8 October for Flipkart Plus, Flipkart Black and Flipkart credit card members, and the public sale runs from 9 October. Amazon's Great Indian Festival had not announced official dates as this playbook went to press on 18 September 2026; reports tracking Amazon's own assistant point to a start between 27 September and 7 October, and the last three editions have all opened in the last week of September with roughly 24 hours of early access for Prime members. Treat that as the planning window, and watch Seller Central for the confirmed date.

If you sell online in India - on Amazon, Flipkart, Meesho, ONDC, quick commerce apps, WhatsApp or Instagram - this is the one stretch of the year when buyers arrive without you having to pay full price to find them. It is also the stretch where an unprepared seller loses money faster than any other: fees, ad spend, stockouts and returns all scale with volume.

This playbook is written for the small seller: the person running a catalogue of 5 to 500 products, often alone or with a tiny team, who cannot afford agencies or a ■50,000-a-month ad budget. Everything here is something you can do yourself, starting this week.

How to use this playbook

If you are already selling, start with Chapter 6 (the T-14 sprint) and Chapter 7 (pricing) - those are the chapters that decide whether this festive season makes you money. If you are starting from zero, read Chapters 4 and 5 first to pick your channel honestly, then aim at the Diwali wave rather than panic-registering this week. Chapters 10 and 11 (GST and cash flow) apply to everyone; they are where festive-season profits usually go to die.

A note on honesty: nothing in these pages guarantees sales. What it does guarantee is that you will avoid the predictable, boring mistakes - mispriced deals, GST surprises, cash stuck in settlements, dead stock in November - that separate the sellers who profit from the sellers who merely post big revenue numbers.

Three sellers, three seasons

Where you start from decides which chapters are really for you, so place yourself honestly in one of these three seats.

- The established seller, 6+ months of sales, ratings and data. Your season is won by Chapter 7 (pricing floors) and Chapter 9 (ads): your listings already convert; margin discipline and paid visibility are your two levers. Skim Chapters 4-5.

- The stalled seller, registered months ago, a few orders a week, never pushed. Your season is won by Chapter 6 (the sprint) and the badges in Chapter 8 - the festive traffic is the cheapest chance you will get all year to build the reviews and velocity that platforms reward. Decide one hero product and go deep on it.
- The new seller, starting this week. Your season is won by Chapter 5: accept that the opening weekend is not yours, and aim everything at arriving well - listings, ratings, dispatch rhythm - for the Navratri-to-Diwali wave and the post-Diwali second wave, which together are bigger than the sales events anyway.

2. The 2026 festive calendar: four waves, not one event

The mistake most first-time festive sellers make is treating the season as one event. It is at least four distinct demand waves, and your stock, pricing and ads should shift between them.

Date (2026)	Event	What it means for you
Late Sep (expected)	Amazon Great Indian Festival opens (Prime early access ~24h earlier)	Wave 1. Amazon's biggest event; runs in themed phases to Diwali. Official dates pending as of 18 Sep - watch Seller Central.
8-9 Oct	Flipkart Big Billion Days (early access 8 Oct, public 9 Oct)	Wave 2. Confirmed by Flipkart on 16 Sep 2026. Short, sharp spike; most demand lands in the first 72 hours.
11-20 Oct	Navratri, ending with Dussehra (20-21 Oct, varies by regional calendar)	Wave 3 begins. Ethnic wear, festive decor, gifting. Tier-2 towns lead.
29 Oct	Karva Chauth	Beauty, fashion, jewellery accessories peak.
6 Nov	Dhanteras	Gold, metal, kitchenware, electronics - traditionally the biggest single buying day.
7-8 Nov	Choti Diwali, then Diwali (8 Nov)	Peak gifting week. Delivery cut-offs matter; buyers start paying for speed.
10-11 Nov	Bhai Dooj	Tail end of gifting; returns begin to appear.
14-15 Nov	Chhath Puja	Strong in Bihar, Jharkhand, eastern UP - relevant if you sell festive food, decor or apparel.
8-25 Nov	The post-Diwali second wave	High-ticket purchases deferred during the sale rush land now. Redseer documented this dual-peak pattern in 2025. Most sellers go dark here - that is the opportunity.

Festival dates follow the lunar calendar and shift by region; Navratri begins 11 October in most published 2026 calendars, and Dussehra falls on 20 or 21 October depending on the regional panchang. Diwali itself is fixed: Sunday, 8 November 2026, with Dhanteras on 6 November. Always re-check your own community's calendar if your category is festival-specific.

Plan your stock in three tranches instead of one: roughly half your festive inventory positioned for Waves 1-2 (the platform sales), a third held back for the Navratri-to-Diwali run (Wave 3), and the rest ready to redeploy into the post-Diwali second wave (Wave 4). If everything sells out in the first week of October, you will spend the most profitable three weeks of the year watching 'out of stock' pages. If nothing sells, you will be sitting on dead stock through November.

The bank-offer multiplier

Both platforms stack bank offers on top of your discount - for Big Billion Days 2026 Flipkart has confirmed 10 percent instant discounts with Axis Bank and ICICI Bank cards, an extra 12 percent for Flipkart Plus and Black members, and 10 percent cashback on first SuperMoney transactions. You pay nothing for these; they simply make your effective price lower. Build your pricing on the price the customer sees after these offers.

Your week-by-week operating calendar

Week	What is happening	What you do
18 Sep - 3 Oct	Last quiet fortnight before the storm (GIF expected late Sep)	Deal nominations, price floors, listing audit, stock into warehouses, ads ramp from T-7.
Late Sep - early Oct	Great Indian Festival opens (watch Seller Central for the date)	Wave 1 live. Peak ad spend in the first 48 hours; check stock and pricing every morning.
1-7 Oct	GIF waves continue	Reorder heroes, throttle ads on sellers, answer every question. Prepare BBD pricing.
8-9 Oct	Big Billion Days: early access 8 Oct, public 9 Oct	Second peak. Flipkart velocity rewards availability - never let a promoted SKU go out of stock.
10-14 Oct	BBD tail; Navratri begins (11 Oct)	Refresh listings with festive wording (only where true); ethnic and decor demand builds.
15-25 Oct	Navratri to Dussehra (20-21 Oct)	Steady promotions; confirm Dhanteras stock with suppliers; start review-request habit.
26 Oct - 4 Nov	Karva Chauth (29 Oct) build-up	Beauty and gifting peak; publish delivery cut-off dates on your listings and status.
5-8 Nov	Dhanteras (6 Nov) into Diwali (8 Nov)	The buying climax. Buyers pay for speed - highlight dispatch times. Last reorder point.
9-14 Nov	Bhai Dooj (10-11 Nov); returns arrive	Process returns daily; review requests after every delivery; Chhath (14-15 Nov) demand in the east.
10-25 Nov	The post-Diwali second wave	Hold prices, keep modest ads running, clear remaining stock at healthy margins.
25 Nov onwards	Season wind-down	Post-mortem, GST filing, data download, next-season plan (Chapter 13).

3. Where the money is going this year

Redseer's September 2026 festive outlook changes the category playbook: for the first time, mobiles and electronics will make up less than half of festive online sales. The growth is in everyday categories.

Category	Festive 2026 growth (Redseer)	What to do with this
Grocery	+48-50%	Fastest-growing category online; grocery overtakes mobiles as the No. 2 online category in 2026.
Beauty & personal care	+35-40%	Small brands are winning here; gifting combos and festive bundles.
Home & furniture	+32-35%	Diwali decor, kitchen and storage see their annual peak.
Fashion	+20-22%	Ethnic and festive wear peaks at Navratri and Diwali; Tier-2+ towns are growing faster than metros.
Electronics	+15-17%	Solid, not spectacular; buyers facing higher prices are choosier.
Mobiles	+5-7%	Slowed by rising memory costs; price-sensitive buyers wait for deals.

Three structural shifts sit behind those numbers, and each one changes a small seller's decisions.

- Quick commerce is the story of the season. Redseer expects quick-commerce festive sales to grow 110-120 percent year on year - roughly six times the growth rate of the rest of e-commerce - and to take about 18 percent of all festive online sales, up from 11 percent last year. The channel reached about USD 9 billion in the first half of 2026, and monthly transacting users have grown from 8 million in mid-2023 to over 60 million. Even if you never list on a quick-commerce app, its ads and delivery norms are training your customers to expect speed.
- Tier 2+ towns are setting the pace in fashion and beauty. Affordable regional assortments and vernacular campaigns are pulling smaller towns ahead of the metros. If your listings are only in English, you are leaving this demand on the table - Flipkart, Meesho and Amazon all support Hindi and other regional listing content.
- Gen Z is now 38-40 percent of online retail users. They discover on Instagram and buy wherever the price-and-trust calculation works. Clean images, honest titles and fast dispatch matter more to them than brand heritage.

What if you sell in the slow categories? Mobiles and electronics are not dead - they still anchor the sales events; they are just growing at 5-17 percent instead of 30-50 percent. If your catalogue is there, the play is different: fewer, deeper deals on hero products rather than a thin discount across everything, because the buyer in these categories is price-comparing across platforms and waiting for the lowest number of the season.

What this means for your category

Fashion (up 20-22 percent, Tier-2 led). Ethnic and festive wear is a calendar business: Navratri (11-20 October) favours garba and festive styles in the west, Karva Chauth (29 October) pulls beauty and ethnic sets, and the Dhanteras-Diwali week is gifting time. Sizing errors are the profit killer in online fashion, so invest your prep hour in complete size charts and measurements rather than in another discount. Fill regional-language fields on your listings - the Tier-2 growth is arriving in Hindi, Tamil, Telugu and other languages, not English.

Home, decor and kitchenware (up 32-35 percent). Diyas, torans, lights, rangoli sets, puja items and metal kitchenware peak hard, with Dhanteras the single biggest day for metal and kitchen

purchases. Buyers need decor before the festival, not on it, so state dispatch and delivery times plainly, and consider festive bundles (diya set plus rangoli plus incense) that lift the order value without extra shipping cost. Bundle thoughtfully: items bought together should share a weight slab.

Packaged food and gifting. GST 2.0 moved most packaged foods - namkeens, bhujia, chocolates, biscuits, dry fruits like almonds and dates - to the 5 percent slab, which resets your pricing headroom. Food selling needs an FSSAI licence, so sort that before listing, not after. The festive hamper is the highest-margin format in this category, and it is where your WhatsApp channel (Chapter 15) beats every marketplace: hampers are personal, customisable and bought late.

Beauty and personal care (up 35-40 percent). Karva Chauth and the wedding season that follows Diwali create two demand spikes for beauty, mehendi and jewellery accessories. Gifting sets and minis outperform full sizes in the festive weeks. Honest ingredient and shade information reduces returns; beauty buyers return what arrives looking different from the listing.

Electronics and accessories (up 15-17 percent). These buyers price-compare across platforms and wait for the lowest number of the season, so align your deepest cut to one hero product and let the bank offers stack on top. State warranty and what-is-in-the-box details clearly - 'adapter not included' discovered after delivery is a one-star review wearing a disguise.

Ten product plays for a small festive catalogue

If you are choosing what to list or make for these eight weeks, here are ten plays that fit a small seller's budget and a calendar-driven buyer. Each one is a starting point to research with your own suppliers and numbers, not a guarantee.

- 1 Navratri ethnic sets (before 11 October). Nine days of repeat demand for chaniya choli-style sets, dupattas and festive accessories. The play: complete size charts, regional-language listings, and stock positioned by end of September.
- 2 Karva Chauth kits (before 29 October). Mehendi cones, sieve-and-thali sets, festive makeup minis. A single-day spike, so order shallow and stop advertising on the day itself; leftover mehendi carries over to the wedding season that follows.
- 3 Dhanteras metal and kitchenware (before 6 November). Buyers treat this day as the auspicious purchase day for metal goods - serving sets, brass decor, steel kitchen bundles. High-intent traffic that converts on clarity, not discounts.
- 4 Diwali decor bundles. Diya sets, rangoli powder packs, tealights and torans sold as one bundle. Bundles lift order value while sharing one shipping slab, and they photograph beautifully for WhatsApp.
- 5 Festive gift hampers. The highest-margin format for a home business: dry fruits, namkeens, artisanal snacks, assembled by you, sold on WhatsApp and Instagram for gifting to families and offices. Order spikes in the 3-4 November window, when hampers are bought late and locally.
- 6 Puja samagri kits. Complete, honestly-priced kits for Lakshmi puja on Diwali day - a product where 'everything in one box' beats shopping across six shops, and buyers pay for the completeness, not a discount.

- 7 Fairy lights and home lighting. Huge demand, brutal price competition from large sellers. Enter only with a genuine edge (design, quality, faster delivery) and make sure you meet whatever safety certification your category requires.
- 8 Bhai Dooj gifting (10-11 November). Sibling gifts: small electronics accessories, personalised items, sweets combos. A quieter day with less competition, perfectly timed to sell your remaining gift stock.
- 9 Post-Diwali home organisation (November). The second wave is not just electronics: after the festival comes the cleaning-and-storage surge. Storage boxes, organisers and kitchen racks sell into late November with almost no festive discounting.
- 10 Winter layers (late November). Seasonal timing overlaps the festive tail: shawls, blankets and thermals for the north. This is how you turn Wave 4 into Wave 5 instead of ending your season on Bhai Dooj.

Notice what these ten have in common: they are all calendar-driven, so your money turns quickly; they are all giftable or bundleable, so order values rise without extra fees; and most are light, so shipping stays in the cheap weight slabs. That combination - fast turns, giftable, light - is the small seller's sweet spot this season.

4. Choosing your channel: where a small seller actually wins

You do not need to be everywhere. You need to be excellent on one platform first, then expand. Spreading a small catalogue and a small budget across three platforms is how first-time sellers end up with three mediocre shops instead of one good one.

Channel	Commission	GST needed?	Best for	Money reaches you
Amazon	Referral fee varies by category (roughly 2-25%), plus closing and fulfilment fees	GST or PAN to register	Branded and premium products; tools (FBA, Sponsored ads) are the strongest in the market	Paid 7 days after delivery, on a 7-day cycle
Flipkart	Category commission plus fixed, shipping and collection fees; registration is free	GSTIN mandatory for taxable goods	Value fashion, festive volume, Tier-2 reach; Big Billion Days is the volume event	Typically 7-15 days after delivery
Meesho	0 percent commission	No - sellers without a GSTIN can sell with an Enrolment ID (intra-state only)	Unbranded, low-price, high-volume lines; the fastest legal way to start selling	7-day payment cycle from delivery
ONDC network	Set by the seller app you join, commonly low single digits	GSTIN generally expected	Local shops and small brands wanting reach without a marketplace's take rate	Varies by seller app
WhatsApp / Instagram	None (you run it)	GST still legally applies to your sales	Building a repeat customer base and festive gift hampers	Instant, via UPI

A few plain truths about each channel, from the platforms' own seller documentation.

Amazon is the most complete machine and the most unforgiving. You can register with just a GST number (or PAN) and a bank account. Fulfilment by Amazon gets you the Prime badge, which matters most during the Great Indian Festival, when buyers filter for fast delivery. Amazon pays you 7 days after delivery on a 7-day cycle, and its fee structure varies by category - always run the fee preview in Seller Central before you price, never from memory.

Flipkart reaches deep into smaller towns, and Big Billion Days delivers the single biggest order spike most Indian sellers see all year. Registration is free. The catch is GST: for taxable goods, a GSTIN is mandatory from your very first sale - the usual Rs 40 lakh turnover threshold does not apply to marketplace sellers, because selling through an e-commerce operator requires registration regardless of turnover. Flipkart deducts category commission plus fixed, shipping and collection fees, charges 18 percent GST on those fees (recoverable as input credit), and deducts 1 percent TCS (also recoverable when you file). Since late 2025 Flipkart has run zero commission on many products under Rs 1,000 - but commission slabs change, so check the live calculator in Seller Hub before pricing anything.

Meesho is the honest starting point for a zero-budget seller. Zero commission, zero penalty for late dispatch or order cancellation (as of its current supplier terms), delivery to more than 28,000 pincodes, and a 7-day payment cycle from the delivery date. Sellers without a GSTIN can register with an Enrolment ID and sell within their own state - a legal testing ground before you formalise. Note that Meesho Ads and some visibility programs currently require a regular GSTIN, which is one more reason to get GST registered when you are ready to scale.

ONDC - the government-backed Open Network for Digital Commerce - is not an app but a network: you join through a seller network participant, list once, and become discoverable across multiple buyer apps with your own store QR code to promote. Commissions are typically lower than marketplaces. It is worth a calm look after the season, not a panicked experiment during it.

Fulfilment: the hidden channel decision

Each marketplace gives you three ways to deliver, and the choice changes your badges, your costs and your sleep.

- Platform fulfilment (FBA on Amazon, Flipkart Fulfilment): you send stock to the platform's warehouse before the sale; they store, pack, ship and handle returns. You earn the Prime or F-Assured badge and the highest conversion. The risks are the stock-in cut-offs (warehouses stop accepting inbound inventory days before the event) and stock you cannot redeploy mid-sale if demand shows up somewhere else.
- Platform logistics, your warehouse (Amazon Easy Ship, Flipkart's standard flow with Ekart pickup): you store and pack, the platform's courier collects. The flexible middle path - your stock stays reachable, the badge is weaker.
- Self-ship: you handle storage, packing and couriating yourself. Maximum control, maximum work, and the weakest placement during a sale, when buyers filter for fast delivery.

A common festive pattern used by experienced sellers: commit about 60-70 percent of your forecast for hero SKUs to platform fulfilment and hold the rest in your own space as the buffer you can point at either marketplace mid-sale. Split that decision per product, not across your whole

catalogue - long-tail items rarely justify warehouse stock.

The one-platform rule

Lead with the platform that fits your product: Flipkart for value fashion and festive volume, Amazon for branded or premium items, Meesho for unbranded low-price lines. Get your first 25 reviews and your fulfilment rhythm on one platform, then add the second in the post-Diwali lull - not in the middle of the sale.

5. Starting from zero this week: an honest plan

Read this chapter sitting down. If you are not already a registered seller, you will not be fully ready for the first day of the Great Indian Festival, and that is fine - the season runs eight more weeks after it. The profitable target for a brand-new seller is the Navratri-to-Diwali wave and the second wave after it, not the opening weekend.

Here is the realistic sequence. GST registration comes first for most routes: it is free on the GST portal, takes about 3-7 working days, and for marketplace sellers it is compulsory for taxable goods regardless of turnover. With your GSTIN in hand, Flipkart's onboarding typically clears in a day or two once documents match exactly - the most common rejection is a name that differs between GST records, PAN and bank details, so make them identical, spacing and punctuation included. Amazon needs your GST (or PAN) plus an active bank account. Meesho is the fastest door of all and will even take you without a GSTIN for intra-state selling while you wait for registration.

- Days 1-7: GST application (if needed) and document hygiene - PAN, bank account in the business's name, pickup address, and product data cleaned up.
- Days 3-10: register on your chosen platform; list 10-20 products with genuinely good photos (white background, 1000x1000 pixels or better, multiple angles) rather than 200 rushed ones.
- Days 10-20: first orders, first dispatches, first reviews. Dispatch speed and photo quality are the two things a new seller fully controls.
- From mid-October: you arrive trained, with ratings, just as the Navratri-Diwali wave builds. That is your launch window, and it is the biggest one anyway.

Two traps to refuse. First, agencies offering 'guaranteed sale participation' for a fat fee this week - the platforms' own seller support and documentation are free, and most of what agencies sell at this stage is form-filling you can do yourself. Second, buying reviews or ratings. Platforms detect it, suspend accounts for it, and a suspension letter in October costs you the entire season.

Set expectations with arithmetic, not dreams. A new seller with 15 decent listings, fast dispatch and a small ad budget should realistically target double-digit daily orders by Diwali week in a decent category - not ten thousand orders. The festive season compounds what you have built; it does not conjure a business from nothing.

The paperwork table

Platform	Register with	Typical first listing	Watch out for
Amazon	GST (or PAN) + active bank account	A day or two after verification	Fee preview before pricing; category approvals for gated lines
Flipkart	GSTIN, PAN, bank account, pickup address, digital signature	Usually 1-2 days once documents match	Name mismatches between GST, PAN and bank - the No.1 rejection cause
Meesho	GSTIN, or Enrolment ID for non-GST sellers (intra-state only)	Often the same week	Ads and some programs need a regular GSTIN; QC engine checks image quality
ONDC (via a seller app)	Business identity, bank details, catalogue, licences like FSSAI if category needs them	Days to about a week via the seller app	Costs and tools differ by seller app - compare before joining

6. The final-fortnight sprint: T-14 to sale day

Everything that can be fixed before a sale opens is worth roughly twice what it is worth during the sale, because during the sale you have no time to fix it. Work this chapter backwards from your platform's opening day - for Big Billion Days that is 9 October, and if Amazon's festival opens in the reported late-September window, run this list against that date too.

T-14 to T-8: fix the shop window

- 1 Audit every listing you plan to push. Title readable and keyword-honest, full attributes filled, at least 4-6 images, size and dimension data correct. One weak hero image costs more sales than a weak discount.
- 2 Rewrite titles for festive search. Add the words people actually type in these weeks - 'gift', 'Diwali', 'Navratri', 'festive', 'puja' - only where they are true for your product. Keyword-stuffed titles depress clicks on mobile, which is where most sale traffic lives.
- 3 Clean your account health. Check Seller Central or Seller Hub for pending issues, unresolved claims and listing-quality flags. A healthy account is a condition for running deals and promotions.
- 4 Set your price floors now, with the worksheet in Chapter 7. Decide today the lowest price each product can go to during the sale - because on day two of the sale, at 11 pm, you will not do this math calmly.

T-7 to T-3: load the machine

- 1 Submit deals and coupons through the platform's deal dashboard the moment the festive nomination window is open for your account - deal slots fill up and close before the sale, not during it. Every platform revises mechanics each year, so confirm current deadlines inside Seller Central and Seller Hub rather than from last year's blog posts.

- 2 Allocate stock. Send bestsellers into platform fulfilment (FBA on Amazon, Flipkart Fulfilment) to earn the Prime and F-Assured badges, but hold 30-40 percent of your forecast in your own space as the buffer you can redirect mid-sale. Never commit stock to a warehouse you cannot replenish.
- 3 Build your ad campaigns now, but leave them off. Separate festive campaigns from your everyday ones so you can control budgets and read results cleanly.
- 4 Prepare your packaging and labels. Returns during festive weeks are high; strong packaging is a returns policy.

T-2 to T-0: final checks

- 1 Freeze changes. No listing rewrites, no category moves, no pricing-structure experiments in the last 48 hours. Change one variable at a time, and change none during launch.
- 2 Ramp ads from about T-7 rather than T-1. Ranking signals take days to register; a budget switched on the night before buys traffic without buying position.
- 3 Charge your phone, brief your family, stock your kitchen. Sale week is a shift job. The sellers who win are simply the ones who show up every hour of it.

The 3:1 rule for your first festive sale

For every hour you plan to spend 'promoting', spend three hours making the listing worth buying: photos, title, reviews, dispatch speed, packaging. Sellers invert this ratio, buy ads to a bad listing, and call the season a failure. The product page is the conversion machine; ads are just the hose.

The 10-point listing audit

Run this on every product you plan to push during the sale. It takes about ten minutes per listing and pays for itself with the first order.

- 1 Title: readable first, keyword-honest second. A buyer should understand what you sell from the title alone, on a phone screen, in two seconds.
- 2 Images: at least 4-6 per product. Main image clean and uncluttered (marketplaces commonly require a plain white background for the main image and check this automatically); the rest showing scale, details, packaging and use.
- 3 Image size: high resolution - 1000 pixels or more per side, so buyers can zoom. Blurry zoom is a silent conversion killer.
- 4 Attributes: every field filled - size, material, colour, dimensions, what is in the box. Blank fields suppress you in filtered searches.
- 5 Measurements in the photos and the text. Returns start with surprise; measurements prevent surprise.
- 6 Description written for the buyer's objections: how it is used, what it is made of, what arrives and what does not.

- 7 HSN code and GST slab correct, so your invoicing and the platform's reports match in November.
- 8 Stock counts accurate in the system, not in your head. Mid-sale, the listing says what the system says.
- 9 Price history consistent: a listing that jumps between wildly different prices invites price-history flags on some platforms; plan your festive price and hold it cleanly.
- 10 Questions in the Q&A; answered. Unanswered questions on a festive listing read like an abandoned shop.

Photography on a phone

Product photos are the closest a marketplace buyer gets to holding your product, and a phone is enough to take good ones. The recipe: shoot near a window in daylight (never under a yellow bulb), tape a plain white sheet as the backdrop for the main image, keep the phone steady and tap to focus, shoot from eight angles - front, back, top, inside, scale reference next to a common object, in use, packaging, and what is in the box - and reject anything slightly blurry. Edit only for brightness and crop, never for colour that misrepresents the product, because returns punish flattery. Two hours of shooting produces a season of listings.

How much stock to buy: a five-step method

- 1 Write your average daily orders per product over the last 30 days. New listing? Use your best comparable product's number, or a conservative one per day.
- 2 Pick a festive multiplier for the sale weeks. For a first festive season, plan 2-4 times your daily average on hero products - platforms and agencies report festive-day spikes several times higher than normal, but overstocking is the more expensive error for a small seller.
- 3 Multiply, add the days you expect to sell, and subtract what you already hold. That is your order quantity.
- 4 Split it: roughly 60-70 percent into platform fulfilment for the badge, the rest in your own space as the mid-sale buffer you can redirect.
- 5 Write your reorder point now: when stock on hand falls below (supplier lead time in days x expected daily sales), order. During the sale you will not have the peace of mind to do this arithmetic, so do it today.

The sprint on one page

Days out	Action	Why it matters
T-14 to T-10	Listing audit: titles, attributes, 4-6 images, HSN codes	Listing quality feeds ranking and deal eligibility
T-12	Account health check; clear pending claims and flags	A healthy account is a condition for running deals
T-10	Compute and write down price floors per product (Ch. 7)	The decision made calmly now saves panic at 11 pm on sale day
T-8	Submit deal nominations and set capped coupons	Deal slots close before the sale begins, not during it
T-7	Stock into platform warehouses for hero SKUs; buffer at home	Stock-in cut-offs and slow warehouse check-in make late arrival risky
T-7	Switch ad ramp on at half your intended daily budget	Ranking signals need days to register before the sale
T-3	Build sale campaigns separate from evergreen ones; keep paused	Clean read on what the festival itself earned
T-1	Freeze all changes; verify every promotion is configured correctly	Misconfigured promotions are the classic day-one horror
T-0	First hour: verify every deal, coupon and price is live and correct	The platform will not fix it for you

7. Pricing that survives the sale: the contribution floor

The festive season is where margins go to die, because discounts stack multiplicatively while your costs barely move. The single most valuable 30 minutes you will spend this fortnight is computing the floor price of each product you plan to discount. Here is the method.

Your floor is the price at which contribution - what is left of the sale price after GST, platform fees and product cost - still clears a minimum you set. Not MRP minus 30 percent; the number the fees leave for you.

A worked example (illustrative numbers - your category, weight slab and fees will differ; recompute with your platform's live fee calculator):

Line item	Sale price A (Rs 799)	10% off (Rs 719)	20% off (Rs 639)
Selling price (incl. 5% GST)	799	719	639
Output GST to government (5%)	-38	-34	-30
Commission (12%)	-96	-86	-77
Fixed/closing fee	-15	-15	-15
Shipping (weight slab)	-70	-70	-70
Collection fee (2%)	-16	-14	-13
GST on platform fees (18%)	-35	-33	-31
Product cost + packaging	-345	-345	-345
Money left per order (contribution)	184 (23%)	122 (17%)	58 (9%)

Read the last row twice. A 20 percent discount did not cut your profit by 20 percent - it cut it by about 70 percent, because commission, shipping and fees shrink only slightly while product cost stays fixed. At Rs 639 you are working for Rs 58 an order; one return, which costs you two-way shipping, erases the profit of four sales.

Now the practical rules that fall out of this arithmetic.

- Set each product's floor before the sale, write it on a sheet next to your desk, and treat it as law. When a competitor drops below your floor during the sale, let them - you cannot win a race to the bottom, only finish it.
- Prefer coupons over blanket price cuts. A coupon is visible to buyers as a discount but lets you keep the list price intact for later, control the budget (coupons can be capped), and switch it off when the cap is hit.
- One hero deal beats ten shallow ones. The platform's ranking systems reward products with a spike of sales velocity; a deep, well-advertised deal on one product lifts its rank, and its halo lifts your other listings.
- Remember the recovery items. The 18 percent GST on platform fees and the 1 percent TCS come back to you as input credit when you file - but with a lag, which is exactly why Chapter 11 exists.
- Watch price parity. Amazon and Flipkart both care whether your price on their platform is higher than elsewhere; a price that undercuts them on your own channels can cost you visibility on theirs.

The worksheet

For each product write five numbers: selling price, output GST rate, total platform fees (from the live calculator, at your intended price), product plus packaging cost, and the contribution that remains. Then write the floor: the price at which contribution hits the minimum you will accept - many small sellers use 10-15 percent during festive weeks. Products that cannot clear the floor at a competitive price are not sale products; sell them at full price to the post-Diwali wave instead.

A second example, on Meesho's zero commission

The same method on a Rs 499 gift hamper with Meesho's 0 percent commission shows why channel choice is a pricing decision. Output GST at 5 percent is about Rs 24; Meesho's shipping (weight-based, shown to you before you price) runs about Rs 60 plus GST; the hamper costs you Rs 260 to assemble. That leaves roughly Rs 144 per order - about 29 percent contribution - before any ad spend. The margin you keep by choosing the right channel for the right product is often larger than the margin you can ever win by discounting harder on the wrong one.

How discounts stack with bank offers

Bank offers cut the price the customer pays without cutting your payout - the bank funds the difference. Stack deliberately:

	Example numbers (Rs)
Your list price	999
Your festive discount (10%)	899
Bank offer during the sale (10%)	Customer pays about 809
Your settlement (based on your price of 899)	Computed on 899, not 809

So when Big Billion Days runs a 10 percent Axis or ICICI instant discount, you do not need to match it from your own margin - your 10 percent plus the bank's 10 percent lands the customer at roughly 20 percent off while your payout is computed on your price. This is the cheapest deep discount you will ever offer; use it on hero products where the psychological price point matters.

8. Deals, coupons and badges

Buying visibility during the big sales is cheaper than earning it, if you use the platform's own machinery. The machinery is deals, coupons and badges - here is how they fit together.

Deals are the platform's discounted showcase slots. Amazon runs Lightning Deals and event-long deals with a fee per deal slot; Flipkart runs its own deal nominations through Seller Hub. Two facts decide your deal strategy. First, deal nominations open weeks before the event and close when slots fill - if you are reading this in late September, check your deal dashboard today, not tomorrow. Second, a deal is a bet on velocity: the platform gives you placement, you give up margin, and the payoff only works if your listing converts the traffic - which brings you back to photos and reviews.

Coupons are the disciplined cousin. A capped coupon - '10% off, first 500 redemptions' - shows the same discount to the buyer while capping your total spend and keeping your list price intact. During the sale, coupons stack on platform bank offers (this year's Big Billion Days includes 10 percent instant discounts on Axis and ICICI cards plus member discounts), so your 10 percent coupon rides a 20 percent bank offer into a much bigger effective discount at no extra cost to you. This is the cheapest visibility you will buy all year.

Badges are silent conversion boosters, and you qualify for them through operations, not money:

- Prime (Amazon) and F-Assured (Flipkart) come from platform fulfilment - send your hero SKUs into FBA and Flipkart warehouses before the sale's stock-in cut-off. Both platforms stop accepting inbound stock ahead of the event; the cut-off for the Great Indian Festival falls in the days just before opening, and warehouse check-in slows badly in the final week, so land your stock early.
- Next Day Dispatch on Meesho - a seller's best free visibility lever - is earned by dispatch discipline in the weeks before the sale. Start treating your dispatch SLA as a marketing channel now.
- A 4.0-plus star rating is a de facto deal-eligibility requirement. Chase honest reviews in September, when each one is cheap to earn, rather than in October when it is too late to matter.

The one deal to refuse

Never fund a deal with a price below your Chapter 7 floor 'because it is good visibility'. Visibility that loses money per unit scales your losses at sale speed. If the deal the platform suggests is below floor, counter with a smaller discount plus a coupon, or decline the slot and let ads do the work.

Choosing between deals, coupons and ads

Tool	Use it when	Cost and risk
Platform deal slot	You have a proven converter and want a velocity spike	Fees per slot; a price below your floor loses money at scale
Capped coupon	You want visible extra discount with a spending cap you control	Cheap; only pays out on redemption
Sponsored ads	Your listing converts but is invisible in search	Flexible budget; wasted if the listing does not convert
Bank offers	Always - they cost you nothing	None; they run on the platform's side
Deep blanket price cut	Almost never	Cuts contribution by more than the discount, page after page

9. Ads on a small budget

You can run a serious festive ad campaign on Rs 300-800 a day if you respect one principle: advertise to convert, not to feel busy. This chapter is that principle made practical.

Start with automatic campaigns. Amazon's Sponsored Products auto campaigns and Flipkart's equivalent discover the search terms that actually convert for your product, at low bids. Let them run for 7-10 days before the sale, then lift the winning terms into exact-match manual campaigns where your money goes only to proven searches. This harvest-and-move pattern is the whole game; most small sellers skip the second step and keep paying discovery prices for proven terms.

Budget shape matters more than budget size. A flat daily budget for a two-week sale wastes half of it on low-intent days. The shape that works:

- Ramp from about T-7, at roughly half your intended daily spend, to build ranking history.

- Peak spend in the first 48 hours of the sale, when total market traffic is at its highest and ranks are being set.
- Second smaller peak at the weekend and again from Dhanteras through Diwali week (2-8 November).
- One sensible planning split used by experienced sellers: about 40-50 percent of the festive promo budget to ads weighted toward the ramp and opening 48 hours, 25-35 percent to discount funding, 10-20 percent held in reserve for mid-sale redeployment, and the rest to creative and content.

Every morning during the sale, look at exactly three numbers: spend, orders, and spend divided by orders. If a campaign's cost per order is under your target, raise its budget 20-30 percent. If it is double, pause it - do not 'give it more time to learn' during a sale; learning is for September, scaling is for October. Watch stock while you scale: the fastest way to torch a rank you paid for is to let an ad keep running after the product goes out of stock.

A note on Meesho Ads and Flipkart's Product Listing Ads: the same harvest-and-move logic applies, and on Meesho remember ads currently require a regular GSTIN. Wherever you advertise, keep sale campaigns separate from everyday ones, or you will never know what the festival actually earned you.

The only ad words you need to know

Term	Plain meaning
CPC (cost per click)	What you pay each time someone taps your ad
CTR (click-through rate)	Share of people who see the ad and click. Low CTR usually means a weak image or title
Orders / conversion	Share of clicks that turn into purchases. If clicks are fine but orders are not, fix the listing, not the ad
Cost per order	Ad spend divided by orders. Your daily steering number
ACoS / TACoS	Ad spend as a share of the sales the ads produced (total ad cost over total sales for the wider view). Lower is better once a campaign matures
Auto vs manual campaigns	Auto lets the platform find your search terms; manual targets exact terms you choose. Harvest from the first, scale with the second

Your first Rs 500: a 7-day starter plan

If ad money is tight, run the smallest honest experiment that teaches you something. Take Rs 500 and one hero product. Day 1-3: Rs 60 a day on an auto campaign, low bids, watching which search terms convert. Day 4: pause the auto campaign, take the two or three search terms that produced orders, and start a manual exact-match campaign at Rs 100 a day on those terms alone. Day 5-7: raise the winner's budget 20 percent a day while its cost per order stays under your Chapter 7 contribution; pause anything that doubles it. That Rs 500 bought you the exact words your buyers use - intelligence you can reuse across every platform, in your titles, in your WhatsApp posts, next season. Scale from knowledge, not hope.

10. GST 2.0 essentials for festive sellers

India's GST structure was overhauled in September 2025 into what everyone now calls GST 2.0: two main slabs - 5 percent and 18 percent - plus a 40 percent rate for sin and luxury goods, effective from 22 September 2025. For a festive seller this matters twice over: it changes what your customers pay, and it sets your invoicing arithmetic.

What moved (from the official announcements):

- Household essentials - soaps, shampoos, toothpaste, toothbrushes, tableware and kitchenware, bicycles - came down to 5 percent.
- Most packaged foods moved to 5 percent: namkeens, bhujia, chocolates, biscuits, pasta, sauces, ice cream, nuts like almonds and dates.
- Big-ticket festive categories came down from 28 to 18 percent: TVs above 32 inches, air conditioners, dishwashers, cement; small cars and two-wheelers up to 350cc likewise.
- Up at 40 percent: tobacco, pan masala, aerated drinks and luxury goods.

Why this matters to your festive plan: several categories got a demand tailwind, because post-GST-2.0 price cuts landed on the same goods that sell during the festival. If you sell in electronics, appliances or packaged food, your pricing conversations this season are happening against visibly lower MRPs on some goods. Your own GST rate determines your invoice arithmetic - know your product's exact slab before you set any price.

The four compliance rules a marketplace seller must not fumble:

- 1 GST registration is mandatory for taxable goods sold through a marketplace, from your very first sale - the normal Rs 40 lakh turnover threshold does not apply to e-commerce sellers (Section 24 of the CGST Act). Composition scheme is not available on marketplaces.
- 2 Platforms deduct 1 percent TCS on your taxable sales and deposit it with the government. It shows up in your GST returns as credit - money blocked until you file, not money lost. Reconcile it every month; unmatched TCS is the most common reason sellers overpay tax.
- 3 Platform fees carry 18 percent GST, which you can claim as input credit. Download the platform's monthly GST invoices from your seller dashboard and book them - most small sellers leave this money on the table every single month.
- 4 If you send stock into a platform warehouse in another state (FBA or Flipkart Fulfilment), that state becomes an Additional Place of Business for GST purposes and typically needs its own registration. Sellers discover this the hard way when stock sits unshippable in a warehouse awaiting an APOB clearance.

During the sale itself, your invoicing volume can jump 5-10 times for days at a stretch. The preparation is boring and worth it: correct HSN codes on every listing now, an invoice format that matches your GSTIN details, and a nightly reconciliation habit so that the November filing season is a formality instead of an emergency. If you are not already filing through a simple software or a filing service, budget for one before Diwali; it costs a few hundred rupees a month and repays itself in one avoided penalty.

Your monthly GST rhythm as a marketplace seller

The dates are fixed and unforgiving; the work is easy if it is routine. For monthly filers: GSTR-1 (your outward sales detail, where the month's sales must match what the platforms report) is due by the 11th of the following month, and GSTR-3B (the return where you actually pay) by the 20th. Smaller taxpayers can opt for the quarterly QRMP scheme - check current eligibility on the GST portal. Put both dates in your phone's calendar now, with a reminder three days before each. During festive months, block the hour in advance: October's sales volume is what makes November's filing a job instead of a formality.

11. Cash flow: the part of the festive season nobody photographs

Festive season cash flow is a timing mismatch: your suppliers, your GST liability and your ad platform all take money on schedule, while your sales revenue arrives on the platform's settlement calendar. Amazon pays 7 days after delivery on a 7-day cycle; Meesho runs a 7-day payment cycle from the delivery date; Flipkart settlements typically run 7-15 days after delivery, longer for new sellers. Returns add another lag - a returned order can hold up settlement for weeks.

Run the timing on a worst-case sale week. An order placed on Big Billion Day, delivered on day 5, returned on day 10, settles perhaps a fortnight after that - while the GST on the original sale and the next month's ad spend are already due. Multiply by a hundred orders and you can have a 'record month' on the dashboard and an empty bank account in real life. Sellers describe this as the festive cash crunch for a reason; it is structural, and it is survivable with two habits.

- Reserve before you spend. Set aside your estimated GST liability (roughly the GST component of your festive sales, minus input credits) in a separate account the week the sales happen. Every rupee of GST you collect belongs to the government; spending it in October makes November a crisis.
- Hold a working-capital cushion of one full reorder of your hero SKU, separate from your ad budget. The mid-sale reorder - placed when your bestseller is selling out - is the highest-return decision of the season, and it is exactly the moment sellers discover they cannot pay their supplier.

Two more timing details worth their own paragraph. Many suppliers offer festive stock on advance payment and raise prices as demand tightens - locking your replenishment price before October is as valuable as any discount you will offer. And platforms run festive-period policy changes (longer returns windows on some categories, changed payouts during events); the announcements sit in your seller dashboard's notifications, which is a tab worth opening once a week this season even when nothing seems wrong.

The 3-account rule

If you do one thing from this chapter: split your money into three accounts - one for receiving settlements, one for GST you have collected but not yet paid, one for operations. Move money between them deliberately, weekly. When the season ends you will know exactly what you earned, what you owe, and what you can reinvest.

A cash-flow timeline you can feel

Date	Event	Money in / out
9 Oct	Big Billion Day order, 300 units of your hero SKU	Nothing in yet
10 Oct	You pay your supplier for the mid-sale reorder	Out: reorder cost, from your cushion
14-18 Oct	Deliveries complete	Nothing in yet - settlement clock starts per order
21-25 Oct	Settlements begin landing (7 days after each delivery)	In: first payouts, minus fees and 1% TCS
11 Nov	GSTR-1 for October due	Paperwork: sales reported, must match platform data
20 Nov	GSTR-3B due: GST on October sales payable	Out: the GST you collected in October, minus input credits

Look at the gap between 10 October and 25 October: two weeks where you have paid suppliers, run ads and shipped hundreds of orders before the first significant money arrives. That gap is the festive cash crunch in one table - and the reason Chapter 11's two habits (GST reserve, reorder cushion) exist.

12. Sale week: running the shop while it is on fire

Sale week is an operations job with a marketing rhythm. Here is the daily loop that works for a one-person or small team.

- 1 Morning (first hour): check overnight orders and stock. If any hero SKU is below two days of cover at current velocity, place the reorder or throttle its ads immediately. A stockout mid-sale does not just cost the day's sales - it resets the ranking you spent weeks building, and Flipkart's ranking in particular punishes a promoted product that goes unavailable.
- 2 Morning (second hour): read last day's numbers - spend, orders, cost per order, returns started. Move ad budgets up or down by the rules in Chapter 9. Pause, never delete: you want the history.
- 3 Midday: dispatch. Aim to clear every order placed before your platform's same-day cut-off. Dispatch speed feeds the badges (Chapter 8) and the reviews (Chapter 13).
- 4 Afternoon: customer questions. Sale-week buyers message before they buy, and the first seller to answer usually wins the order. Check the Q&A; section on your listings too.
- 5 Night: tomorrow's pricing and coupon check. Verify every promotion is live and correctly priced - misconfigured promotions are the classic day-one horror story, in both directions: a discount that did not switch on, or one that switched on deeper than your floor.

On returns, prevention beats processing. Most festive returns come from expectation mismatch, which means they come from lazy listings: wrong dimensions, flattering-but-dishonest photos, missing 'what's in the box' details. Fix the listing, and the return rate follows. When returns do arrive, process them daily - a pending return blocks settlement and, on some categories, re-saleable stock during the highest-demand fortnight of the year.

Protect your sanity with one rule: no structural changes during the sale. No new categories, no redesigns, no platform experiments. You are running a shop during a stampede; your only jobs are stock, speed, answers and arithmetic.

When things go wrong during the sale

What happened	Your first response
A deal did not go live at launch	Check the deal dashboard for rejection or eligibility reasons; convert to a capped coupon immediately so the day is not lost
A listing got suppressed	Open Seller Central / Seller Hub support chat at once; suppressed listings are usually a compliance flag (image, claim, category) fixed in minutes if caught early
Hero SKU went out of stock	Pause its ads immediately, request the fastest replenishment, and keep the listing active with an expected-availability date rather than delisting
A price glitch (too deep or too shallow)	Fix the price, then verify from the buyer side (app, not dashboard). Report platform-side display errors through support the same hour
Courier pickup missed	Rebook for the earliest slot and inform affected buyers through the platform's messaging - silence creates the complaints, not the delay
Account health dropped	Read the specific metric, fix the underlying orders or claims, and reply to the notification - health issues fester when ignored, and recover fast when addressed

13. The Diwali second wave and the post-sale fortnight

Here is the pattern most sellers miss: the sale events end, everyone goes quiet, and then India keeps buying. Redseer documented a dual-peak in recent festive seasons - a second wave of purchases after Diwali, led by high-ticket items, as buyers who deferred during the sale rush return with their wallets, and as delivery delays push some purchases past the festival itself. The post-Diwali fortnight is the highest-margin selling window of the season precisely because most of your competition has gone home.

So plan Wave 4 explicitly:

- Hold your prices (or most of them) through mid-November. The deep-discount pressure ends with the platform events; buyers in the second wave are choosing on availability and trust, not on the last rupee.
- Keep a modest ad budget running - cost per click typically falls after the sales end, while buying intent for Dhanteras, Diwali, Bhai Dooj and Chhath (14-15 November) continues.

- Bank the reviews. The fortnight after a sale is when your buyers write them, if you ask. A short, polite, honest review request inside the platform's own messaging - not SMS spam - converts best right after delivery. Every review earned now is free ranking for next season.
- Clear returns and reconciliations fast, while records are fresh. This is also when you download your sale reports and capture the data this playbook keeps asking you for: which products earned their margin, which ads paid, which dates delivered.

Then do the quiet post-mortem that turns one good season into a business. Half a page is enough: top 3 products by contribution (not revenue), the one discount you regret, the one you under-cut, stock you ran out of, stock you still hold, and the single change you will make next September. Put a calendar reminder for next August with that page attached. The sellers who dominate a festive season are the ones who took notes in the previous one.

And a word for the end of the tunnel: 20-25 November. The season is over, the second wave has passed, and what remains is your actual business - ideally with a customer list, better rankings, cleaner listings and more reviews than you started with, plus cash reserves that survived GST week. That is what winning the festive season means. Not the biggest sales chart. The strongest January.

Two review messages that work (edit to your voice)

After a smooth delivery

Namaste! Your order was delivered today - thank you for buying from our small business. If everything arrived as expected, a two-line review on the listing genuinely helps a seller like us. If anything is not right, please message us here first and we will fix it. - Happy Diwali!

After the festive rush

Thank you for shopping with us this festive season. If a moment of your time is possible, your honest review helps other buyers find us. We are a small team, and every review matters. Wishing you and your family a wonderful season ahead.

14. Quick commerce and ONDC: should you bother this season?

Quick commerce is the growth story of 2026 - festive sales on the channel are projected to grow 110-120 percent, taking roughly 18 percent of all festive online sales. Should a small seller chase it in the next three weeks? Usually, no - and here is the honest reasoning.

Quick-commerce platforms (Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy Instamart and others) are not open marketplaces. They typically buy your inventory through purchase orders, stock it in their dark stores and sell it themselves; you are a supplier fulfilling a category manager's forecast. Onboarding a new brand generally runs several weeks - entity documentation, brand and trademark checks, state-wise GST registrations for the states you supply, and commercial terms that usually include commissions and deposit models for newer brands. Starting that process in mid-September means arriving after Diwali. If quick commerce is your plan, start the conversation

now for a post-season or next-festive launch - and remember you need working capital to fulfil purchase orders ahead of payment, not after a sale like a marketplace.

What you can do this season with zero onboarding: sell the categories quick commerce has made habitual. The 10-minute apps have trained a large slice of India to expect festive and gifting items delivered fast - impulse sweets, small gifts, puja items, decor. If your marketplace listings cover these and you dispatch same-day, you are already catching the demand the apps created.

ONDC, the government-backed open network, is the calmer long-term play for a small seller. You join through a seller network participant (many offer simple app-based onboarding, some with Hindi-first flows), list once, and become visible across multiple buyer apps, with your own store QR code to share on WhatsApp and print at your shop. Costs and commissions are set by the seller app you choose and are typically lower than the big marketplaces. The Ministry of MSME also runs support programs for small enterprises joining digital commerce through ONDC under its RAMP programme - check current eligibility and details on the official MSME and ONDC portals rather than through agents. The realistic note: ONDC volumes per seller are still smaller than the marketplaces', so treat it as a second channel with better economics, not a replacement - and set it up in the quiet weeks, not now.

15. Selling on WhatsApp and Instagram this festive season

Marketplaces bring strangers; WhatsApp and Instagram bring people who already know you. For gifting, hampers, customised orders and local delivery, these channels earn the best margin in Indian small business - no commission, no ads (unless you choose them), and payment by UPI reaching you the same minute. The festive season is when this channel earns its keep, because gifting demand is personal, last-minute and word-of-mouth.

Set the shop up properly once, and it runs all season:

- WhatsApp Business (the free app, not a personal account): a complete profile with your catalogue of festive products, quick replies for the ten questions everyone asks, labels to track orders (New, Paid, Shipped, Done), and an away message for the hours you are packing orders.
- Status as your storefront: post daily - what shipped today, what is new, how many of last year's gift boxes are left. Status disappears in 24 hours, which makes urgency honest instead of manufactured.
- Broadcast lists, not groups: a broadcast message reaches each customer individually (and only if they have saved your number), without exposing your customer list to each other. Build your lists now - every marketplace buyer who has messaged you is a candidate.
- Payments: share your UPI ID or QR with every order. Money arriving instantly is your working capital during the settlement-lag weeks of Chapter 11.

- Instagram, simply: switch to a professional account, keep 6-9 festive posts alive in a highlight called 'Festive 2026', and reply to every comment and DM as if it were a shop counter - because it is.

Two cautions. Every rule that applies to a marketplace applies here too: GST on your sales is due regardless of channel, and food sellers still need their FSSAI licence. And keep records - a simple spreadsheet of orders, or a small invoicing app - because October memory does not survive to November filing.

The channel-stacking plan

The strongest small-seller combination this season: marketplaces for discovery volume, WhatsApp-Instagram for repeat customers and hampers. Every marketplace order ships with a small card carrying your WhatsApp number. The marketplace finds the customer once; the WhatsApp channel keeps them forever - at zero commission.

16. Master checklists

Print this chapter or keep it open on a second screen through the season. Each list is deliberately short enough to actually finish.

Before the sales open (this week)

- 1 Festive calendar saved, with my platform's confirmed dates and stock-in cut-offs marked.
- 2 Deal nominations submitted in Seller Central / Seller Hub; coupon budgets and caps set.
- 3 Price floor computed per product (Chapter 7) and written where I can see it.
- 4 Hero SKUs into platform fulfilment; 30-40 percent of forecast held in my own buffer.
- 5 Ads: auto campaigns harvesting since T-7; manual exact-match campaigns built and paused.
- 6 Account health clean; listings audited (title, attributes, 4-6 images, HSN codes correct).
- 7 GST account reconciled through last month; TCS and platform-fee credits claimed.
- 8 Three accounts set up: settlements, GST reserve, operations.
- 9 Supplier reorder prices locked for a mid-sale replenishment.

During the sale (daily loop)

- 1 Stock check on hero SKUs; reorder or throttle ads if under two days of cover.
- 2 Yesterday's numbers read: spend, orders, cost per order; budgets adjusted.
- 3 Every order before cut-off dispatched; tracking updated.
- 4 Buyer messages and Q&A; answered.
- 5 Every promotion verified live and correctly priced.
- 6 Returns processed; no return sitting unactioned overnight.

7 End of day: two-line journal - what sold, what surprised me.

After Diwali (the second wave and the wind-down)

- 1 Prices held through mid-November; ads still on, at a lower budget.
 - 2 Review requests sent inside the platform after each delivery.
 - 3 Sale reports downloaded; contribution (not revenue) computed per product.
 - 4 TCS and input credits reconciled; GST return filed on time.
 - 5 Post-mortem half-page written; calendar reminder set for next August.
 - 6 Next season's first decision made: which channel to deepen, which to drop.
-

17. Questions sellers actually ask

Can I sell online without GST?

On Meesho, yes, with an Enrolment ID - but only to buyers within your own state, and without access to ads. On Amazon and Flipkart, a GSTIN is mandatory for taxable goods from your first sale; the usual Rs 40 lakh turnover threshold does not apply to marketplace sellers. GST registration is free on the government portal and takes about 3-7 working days.

Do I need to register a company?

No. Most small sellers operate as sole proprietors; the platforms only ask for GST/PAN and a bank account. Register a company later, when banks, brand deals or partners require it.

How much money do I need to start?

A Meesho reseller can start with zero inventory. A small marketplace seller with 10-20 products and a modest ad budget can start meaningfully in the low tens of thousands of rupees - most of it stock, which is money that comes back as sales rather than fees.

My product went out of stock mid-sale. Now what?

Pause its ads the moment you see two days of cover left, place the fastest replenishment you can afford, and keep the listing live with an availability date. A short gap costs less than a week-long delisting. Then write it in your post-mortem - the stockout is the season teaching you next year's reorder point.

A competitor just went below my price. Should I follow?

Only down to the floor you computed in Chapter 7, never below it. You cannot control their costs, only your own losses. Below your floor, the rational move is to let them sell and take the traffic your reviews and dispatch speed earn instead.

Are paid deal slots worth it?

When the listing converts - good images, healthy rating, proven demand - a deal slot is often the cheapest concentrated visibility you can buy. When the listing is weak, a deal is paying to send traffic to a closed shop. Fix the listing first; the 3:1 rule (Chapter 6) applies.

When do I actually get paid?

Amazon: 7 days after delivery, on a 7-day cycle. Meesho: 7-day payment cycle from the delivery date. Flipkart: typically 7-15 days after delivery, longer for newer sellers. All three deduct fees, and marketplace TCS (1 percent) is withheld and credited back through your GST returns.

Is it too late to register and still catch the season?

For the opening weekend, yes - and it does not matter. Register now and you arrive with listings, ratings and dispatch rhythm just as the Navratri-to-Diwali wave builds, which is the bigger window anyway. And the season after this one starts in January with the Republic Day sales; every platform habit you build now compounds.

Can I really run this alone?

For a catalogue of a few dozen products, yes - Chapter 12's daily loop is a one-person job during the peak, and a family member covering dispatch and messages is the difference between surviving sale week and enjoying it. Beyond that, the first hire that pays for itself is someone who packs.

What if the sale went badly - I discounted too deep and lost money?

Stop discounting immediately, hold your prices through the post-Diwali second wave, and sell your remaining stock at full margin there - it is the highest-margin window of the season precisely because everyone else has gone quiet. Then redo the Chapter 7 worksheet with your real numbers. Every seller has one bad festive season in them; the ones who have two are the ones who skipped the worksheet twice.

18. The plain-English glossary

The festive-season conversations you will hear in seller groups and dashboards, translated.

Term	What it means
BBD / GIF	Flipkart Big Billion Days / Amazon Great Indian Festival - the two flagship sale events
SKU	One distinct product in your catalogue (a red kurta in size M is its own SKU)
MRP	Maximum retail price printed on the product; your selling price is what you actually list at
Contribution	What a sale leaves you after GST, platform fees and product cost - the number Chapter 7 is about
FBA / Flipkart Fulfilment	Sending your stock to the platform's warehouse; they store, pack and ship, and you earn the badge
Easy Ship / Ekart	You store and pack, the platform's courier collects and delivers
Prime / F-Assured badge	The fast-delivery trust badge buyers filter by during sales
NDD	Next Day Dispatch - Meesho's program rewarding fast dispatch with visibility
Buy Box	The main 'Add to Cart' offer on a listing; on Amazon, competing sellers share one page
TCS	Tax collected at source - the 1% the platform deducts from your sales and credits back through your GST returns
ITC	Input tax credit - the GST you paid on purchases and platform fees, claimable against what you owe
APOB	Additional Place of Business - the GST registration you add when your stock sits in another state's warehouse
HSN code	The classification code that determines your product's GST slab and appears on every invoice
Settlement	The payout of a completed order to your bank account, after fees
RTO	Return to origin - a delivery that failed and came back, costing you both-way shipping
ACoS / TACoS	Ad spend as a share of the sales those ads produced - your ad efficiency yardstick
GMV	Gross merchandise value - total sales value on a platform, the headline number in festive news
ONDC / SNP	The Open Network for Digital Commerce, and the Seller Network Participant you join it through
Dark store	The small local warehouse a quick-commerce platform delivers from

Appendix: your festive worksheets

Photocopy these or rebuild them in a spreadsheet. Filled in honestly, they are the whole method of this playbook compressed onto three pages.

Worksheet 1: the price-floor sheet

For every product you plan to discount, fill one row before the sale starts. Use your platform's live fee calculator for the fees column at your intended price, not last year's numbers.

Product	Selling price (Rs)	Output GST (Rs)	Platform fees (Rs)	Product + packaging cost (Rs)	Contribution (Rs)	My floor price (Rs)

Worksheet 2: the stock-planning sheet

One row per SKU. The multiplier is 2-4 times your recent daily average for hero products in a first festive season; use the lower end if you are unsure, because overstock outlives the season while a modest stockout only outlives the week.

SKU	30-day avg orders/day	Multiplier	Sale days	Order qty	To platform fulfilment	My buffer	Reorder point

Worksheet 3: the post-mortem half-page

Fill this in the last week of November and set a calendar reminder for next August with a photo of it attached. Next season starts with this page.

Question	Your answer
Top 3 products by contribution (not revenue)	
The discount I regret	
The discount I cut too shallow	
What ran out, and when	
What is still on my shelf, and why	
What ads taught me about my buyers	
The one change for next September	

Sources and verification

This playbook was researched and verified on 18 September 2026 from: Flipkart's official Big Billion Days 2026 announcement (16 September 2026, confirming 8-9 October dates, member early access and bank offers); Amazon's official seller documentation at sell.amazon.in; Meesho's official supplier site (supplier.meesho.com); the ONDC network's official seller pages (ondc.org); Redseer Strategy Consultants' India Online Retail 2026 festive outlook (September 2026, as reported by The Hindu and on redseer.com); the Press Information Bureau's official releases on the GST 2.0 reforms (September 2025); and published 2026 Hindu festival calendars (regional dates for Navratri, Dussehra, Govardhan Puja, Bhai Dooj and Chhath vary by one day across regional traditions). Amazon's Great Indian Festival 2026 dates were not officially announced at the time of writing; the window stated here reflects reporting of Amazon's own assistant and three years of the event's history - confirm the date in Seller Central. Platform fees, commissions and policies change frequently: always verify current numbers in your own seller dashboard before pricing or committing stock. Nothing in this playbook is legal or tax advice; for your specific situation, consult a qualified professional.